ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Can a Person Bypass Nature?

Derech Hashem 3:2:2-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 2, paragraphs 2-5 (ending in the middle of paragraph 5) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 15 November 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

From dreams to Ruah HaKodesh and prophecy

After a break, the Rabbi recalled that chapter 1 dealt with the five parts of the soul, sleep and dreams, which play such a central part in Sefer Bereshit. Above dreams comes Ruah HaKodesh, divine spirit: not being told something in clear terms, but feeling something during the day. Above that is prophecy, which is communication between a person and God. Those come in chapter 3. Chapter 2 is about manipulating the world, for good using God's names, and for bad through witchcraft.

Paragraph 1 had reminded us that everything in this world has a mirror above, and that every created thing exists through a chain of energy which starts on high and is diluted as it comes down to the physical world.

Paragraph 2: going straight to the root

God also made another way for the physical world to be affected: energy can come down directly, without the regular chain, and then the constant nature of things can change. Nature runs through the chain, and while we live within it everything follows the laws of science. But it is possible to bypass the chain and go to the root.

The Rabbi compared the chain to the coding of a computer program or to DNA: "If you bypass the code, you end up with a different product."

Just as a person may use nature, so he may use this power. But nature has rules: a knife cuts, a ladder lets you climb, you cannot fly without wings. So too this spiritual ability has borders and a framework. "This is another mistake people make." People imagine that a holy person can do any miracle at all and ascribe every fantastic story to him. It does not work like that.

A participant asked about miracles that God Himself performs. The Rabbi recalled the disagreement learned earlier: for the Rambam every miracle was set in place during the six days of creation, while for the Ramhal, when God wants a miracle He simply suspends nature and has no limitation. Here, though, we are speaking about a human being working the system, and that has limits.

Paragraph 3: loosening the soul's ropes

There is a second way to reach results beyond the ordinary. We are body and soul, and the Neshamah is tied up in the "ropes" of the body. That is the normal state, as God wished it. But God made it possible for a person to loosen those ropes a little. When the soul is slightly freer, it has more contact with the divine and reaches deeper and higher understanding. Remember that in sleep only part of the soul leaves us, and even so it comes back with more than we knew.

So paragraph 2 is about bypassing nature by going to the source; paragraph 3 is about the soul being allowed to express itself more, without bypassing nature at all.

Stories of saddikim, and how to hear them

A participant told a family story of a visit to the Baba Sali about a very ill child, who blessed a biscuit to be given to the boy. The Rabbi said such a case would fit paragraph 3 more than paragraph 2: less a manipulation of nature, more a soul with greater access to things.

He then quoted a saying he attributed to the Satmar Rebbe of an earlier generation: anyone who believes all the stories is a fool, and anyone who believes they could not have happened is a heretic. "And that's the correct approach." Whether particular stories are true he does not know, and he is personally more sceptical. Could they have happened? "100% they could have happened." That is what we are learning: the theory of how it is possible.

Paragraphs 4-5: everything depends on God

Paragraph 4 repeats the point. God made it possible to loosen the hold of the physical and connect with the spiritual even while in the body. But again, "don't go overboard": both methods work only within limits, in specific ways.

How do they work? Everything depends on God. Even though there is a chain upon chain, if God stopped willing the world for a moment, it would cease. The Rabbi repeated his analogy: close your eyes and build a beautiful world in your mind, with beaches and palm trees. The phone rings, you turn your attention away, and that world is gone in a second. So too the entire universe exists within God's will. He gives energies to the highest angels, they pass them on to lower ones, and so down to us. That is the normal way.

Paragraph 5 begins to show how the chain can be bypassed: by connecting to God Himself, through His true name. God wishes to be called by His name, "this is My name forever". The participants discussed which name is meant, and the Rabbi said it is probably the forty-two letter name, used on special occasions.

Not magic

The Rabbi stressed that mentioning a name is not magic. "If I happen to know this name and I mention it, I don't think it would work." It must come with the right meditations and framework. Then you are connected to the source of everything, and things are much easier. Even so, the source may refuse. And someone who connects for the wrong purposes may still be allowed through, but "you're going to have to deal with that later on". How this works in detail would continue on Thursday.

Summary

- Nature runs through an ordered chain from God down to the physical world.
- One way beyond nature is to go straight to the root; another is for the soul to be loosened from the body.
- Both have rules and limits, like nature itself; no holy person can do "anything".
- Stories of miracles: do not believe them all, but do not deny they could happen.
- Everything exists only through God's will, and connecting to Him through His name is not magic but requires the right framework.

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